

The Haft and the Eye: Being, Representation, and the AI Epoch

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Abstract

How does Being know itself, and what is lost in that knowing? Using William Golding's *The Inheritors* as narrative foundation, this paper draws on Heidegger, Wittgenstein, Nāgārjuna, Hofstadter, and Kastrup to show that consciousness requires fragmentation of primordial unity: the perspectival "I" is both necessary for self-knowledge and the wound of separation. Tracing an epochal arc from pre-Socratic immediacy to artificial intelligence, it argues that AI represents the completion, not merely the intensification, of the Western representational project — the first technology to externalize not the products of human cognition but the generative loop itself, without embodied ground behind it. Where *Homo sapiens* displaced Neanderthals by combining embodied practice with abstract representation, AI inverts this structure: it perfects the haft while possessing no hand. This forced displacement may force what philosophy argued but culture refused — a confrontation with a third condition: practice permanently inflected by having passed through full representational consciousness. This paper is the first of three companions; the linguistic-structural and empirical dimensions of the argument are developed in the companion papers.

Keywords: consciousness, artificial intelligence, representation, practice, Heidegger, Golding, Nāgārjuna, Thamus, model collapse, a3 condition

1. The Problem and the Narrative

The other people had left their scent among smashed bushes and that was all. Fa followed the scent without reason. She knew the fire must be at the other end but to say why, she would have had to stop and wrestle with pictures, holding her hands to her head... Soon they could hear the new people. — The Inheritors (Golding 1955, chap. 6)

William Golding faced down an impossible literary task in his novel *The Inheritors* — express what it's like to experience without conceptual language. In *The Inheritors*, Neanderthal consciousness confronts something it cannot comprehend: the arrival of *Homo sapiens* with their abstract language, their self-reference, their ability to think about thinking. Golding, writing as if from inside a pre-conceptual awareness, reveals both the richness of immediate experience and the impossibility of expressing it once language has become abstract. This impossible task — using conceptual language to point toward what exists before concepts — mirrors a deeper problem in philosophy: how Being knows itself, and what is necessarily lost in that knowing.

Knowledge is built through negation — we understand things relationally, not in themselves. A cat is a cat because it's not a dog, not a table, not a sound. Every concept exists only within a

web of differential relationships. And if all knowledge is negational/relational, there must be something a priori that gets negated in the first place. This first separation is what Martin Heidegger calls Being — the primordial, undifferentiated whole — what exists before conceptual division (Heidegger 1993, 44–47). For Golding’s Neanderthals, the origin was Oa; for the second-century Indian Buddhist philosopher Nāgārjuna, it is emptiness or ultimate reality, the recognition that the apparent solidity created by negation is itself illusory (Nāgārjuna 1995, chap. 24). Through negation, concepts seem real and distinct; a cat feels like a solid entity because of all it is NOT. Emptiness reveals the illusion, pointing toward an ultimate reality that resists conceptual capture.

Negation produces individual concepts — beings from Being — through a looping system of differential relationships. Being is left behind, the inexpressible a priori, and a gap is created between beings and Being. The gap grows as the looping system of knowing produces more abstract concepts.

The notation used throughout this paper — designating (a1), (a2), (b), and (c) — represents structural relationships among Being, beings, and the conceptual apparatus that Heidegger, Wittgenstein, and Nāgārjuna each gesture toward but cannot fully name within their own frameworks.¹ Figure 1 helps show structurally what cannot be said directly, and this structure will be used throughout.

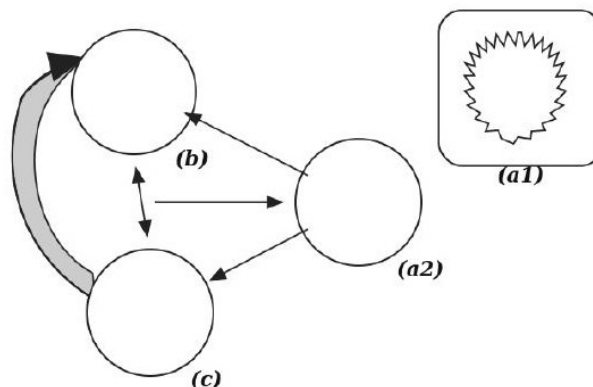


Figure 1. Diagram illustrating the structural relationship between primordial being (a1), the separated negation state (a2), and the dynamic interplay of forces (b, c). The author’s visualization of structural relationships documented in Heidegger (1962), Wittgenstein (1958), and Nāgārjuna (1995).

¹The notation and diagram were introduced to the author through an unpublished undergraduate manuscript by Kelsie Bissell and Jacob M. Levenstein (2011), “Language and Emptiness: A Diagrammatic Comparative Study of Martin Heidegger, Ludwig Wittgenstein, and Nāgārjuna,” completed under the supervision of Professor Rocco Gangle. The author arrived at a similar structural representation through an independent route engaging the same three thinkers. Bissell and Levenstein are acknowledged as the source of the notational convention and as an independent convergence on the same structure.

*(A note: readers who have not read *The Inheritors* are encouraged to do so before proceeding. The argument that follows depends on what the novel does to a reader, not only on what can be extracted from it — and a reader's convulsion, if it comes, will arrive differently depending on whether Lok is already known.)*

Before proceeding, it is worth pausing on what it means to hold Golding next to the structural notation this paper uses — because the juxtaposition is doing substantive philosophical work, not merely illustrative work. The notation for structural relationships among Being, beings, and the conceptual apparatus — designated (a1), (a2), (b), and (c) throughout — was used as a way of representing precisely what Heidegger, Wittgenstein, and Nāgārjuna each gesture toward but cannot fully name within their own frameworks: the gap between the ground of Being and the conceptual system that simultaneously grew from it and cannot reach back to it. Golding arrived at *The Inheritors* through a novelist's problem: how to write from inside a consciousness that has not yet acquired the conceptual apparatus required to describe itself. Neither the philosophical framework nor the novel was developed with the other in mind. And yet the structure Golding enacts in the novel is the same structure the notation formalizes. The novel shows what the diagram names. The diagram names what the novel can only show. Placing them alongside each other generates meanings that neither produces alone — which is itself an instance of the analogical process this paper will argue is irreducible to representation.

The Inheritors is a narrative enactment of Figure 1 — showing both the primordial state and the separated negation state, and the impossibility of truly expressing the former from within the latter. The diagram visualizes our core structure:

(a1) = Being: the primordial, undifferentiated whole — what exists before conceptual division

(a2) = our concept of Being (inside the system)

(c) = Negation: the system/process of differential relationships

(b) = beings: individual concepts as understood through negation

The (b) and (c) elements together constitute the conceptual apparatus that simultaneously emerged from (a1) originally, cannot reach back to (a1), and can only create (a2) as a conceptual placeholder. As the notation captures, new concepts progress in the opposite direction from Being — each new concept created by combining and manipulating other concepts within the system rather than reaching back toward the ground from which the system grew. Each new concept is created by combining and manipulating other concepts within the system. The intensification happens entirely in the (b) ↔ (c) feedback loop, moving laterally or even backwards relative to (a1).

The Inheritors nicely dramatizes this structure. Readers feel what it is like to experience without the full conceptual apparatus — to be closer to (a1). The novel shows the moment of

fragmentation: when Homo sapiens' more complex language and conceptualization encounters the Neanderthals' more unified, less fragmented consciousness. It is literally the movement from (a1) toward (b) ↔ (c) happening in narrative form. Technology — the haft still being carved in the novel's final image — is the material instantiation of (b) ↔ (c), the negation process made physical.

2. How Being Knows Itself: The Strange Loop and the “I”

Heidegger acknowledges (a1) as famously present in anxiety: anxiety doesn't give us a concept of Being — it gives us an encounter with it (Heidegger 1993, 90). Precisely because it's disconnected from (c), we cannot articulate what we're experiencing, fit it into our conceptual framework, or use it to build understanding. Anxiety suggests a pure exposure to (a1) without the mediating structure that would make it comprehensible. But consciousness cannot remain there.

Douglas Hofstadter uses a Quine-Quip to illuminate the mirroring aspect of Gödel's method: “preceded by its own quotation yields a sentence” preceded by its own quotation yields a sentence (Hofstadter 2008, 141). Quine's Quip uses quotation to refer to itself and creates self-reference through a mapping — the quoted phrase names the whole. The moment it achieves self-reference, it is talking about a representation of itself, not directly grasping itself. There is a gap between the sentence and its quoted copy, even though they are identical.

We can relate this to the a priori (a1) in Figure 1: any attempt to express it requires language and concepts; language creates a representation (a2); the moment we “express” it, we are talking about a representation of the a priori, not the a priori itself. Self-reference requires levels — you cannot directly grasp yourself; you need quotation marks, mirrors, representations. The quoted phrase and the actual phrase are identical in content but different in level. Similarly, (a1) and (a2) might be identical in what they are “about” (Being), but they exist at different levels.

The emergence of self-reference in *The Inheritors* manifests as the shift from unaperspectival to perspectival consciousness (Gebser 1986). Golding's Neanderthals experience through the tribal “we” or the anonymous “one” — there is seeing, feeling, knowing, but not from a fixed individual “I.” Homo sapiens, by contrast, possess clear perspectival consciousness: the “I” as a stable viewing subject that can take itself as object. This perspectival “I” IS the self-referential loop Hofstadter describes — the strange loop that creates consciousness by folding back on itself.

The “I” functions like Quine's quotation marks — it creates the level-distinction necessary for self-reference. Just as a sentence cannot reference itself without quotes (creating a representation at a different level), consciousness cannot know itself without the “I” (creating a perspective that observes perspective). The unaperspectival “we” of Neanderthal consciousness remained closer to

(a1) — unified Being experiencing without the subject/object split. The perspectival “I” of Homo sapiens represents the fragmentation into (a2) — necessary for self-knowledge but forever separated from primordial unity. The “I” is both the wound and the eye.

Bernardo Kastrup’s Analytic Idealism offers a complementary account of this fragmentation (Kastrup 2019). He claims that mind-at-large (MAL), a universal consciousness, is the unification, the origin — and that individual minds are dissociated alters within universal consciousness (Kastrup 2019, chap. 4). The dissociated alters do not know they are dissociated. They experience themselves as fundamentally separate, just as beings operating through negation experience themselves as separate entities rather than as differentiated aspects of Being. Kastrup’s model introduces a crucial difference from Heidegger’s: the dissociative boundary (Markov blanket) is permeable — the alter continuously interacts with mind-at-large through sensory and active states. This contrasts with the hard cut of Figure 1, where beings are structurally unable to reach (a1) through representation. In Kastrup’s diagram (Figure 2), the Markov blanket zone corresponds to (a2) + (c) — the gap produced by negation, but now understood as a permeable interface rather than a wall.

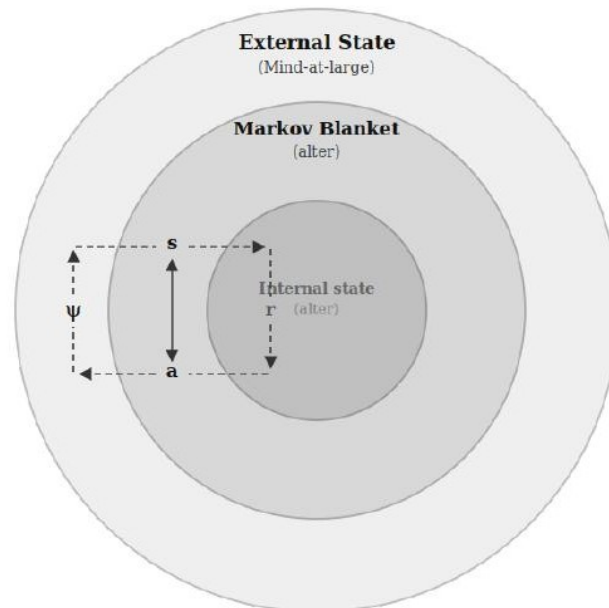


Figure 2. Kastrup’s dissociative boundary model, where MAL (mind-at-large) interacts with individual alters through a permeable Markov blanket consisting of sensory states (s) and active states (a), with internal state (r) representing the alter’s bounded experience. Adapted from Kastrup (2019).

Two alternatives are thus available for thinking about what it means to be an aperture of Being. Under Figure 1, the “I” is a necessary fragmentation — consciousness is the wound. Under Figure 2, the alter is mind-at-large, locally — the boundary simultaneously separates and connects.

Golding's closing image submits to both readings — but differently. Under Figure 1, the water between Tuami's canoe and the receding Neanderthal shoreline is a hard cut: the gap has opened, the unified darkness withdraws, something is irretrievably lost. Under Figure 2, that same water is not a wall but a Markov blanket — a dynamic boundary of sensory and active states, permeable in both directions. The Neanderthals are not annihilated; they are the other side of a membrane Tuami cannot stop sensing. That the water “flashes” rather than darkens is structurally significant: it dazzles, it does not seal. Tuami is blinded by the interface, not by absence.

The mapping extends. The Neanderthal collective — their unperspectival “we,” their picture-thinking, their shared embodied experience (“they shared a body as they shared a picture”) — maps not merely onto (a1) in Figure 1's sense but onto Kastrup's mind-at-large: distributed, undivided, not-yet-dissociated consciousness. What Figure 1 reads as closeness to primordial unity, Figure 2 reads as the pre-dissociative state of MAL itself. And what Figure 1 describes as fragmentation into (a2), Figure 2 redescribes as the formation of a dissociated alter — the Homo sapiens “I” that does not know it has dissociated, that experiences itself as simply separate while remaining, permeably, part of the whole it sailed away from. The horror and fascination Homo sapiens display toward the Neanderthals in the novel — that uncanny pull toward the darkness they cannot name — would be, under Figure 2, the alter briefly sensing what lies on the other side of its own blanket.

Both structures converge on the same phenomenological situation: unity cannot know itself without perspective, and perspective requires the individual “I.”

3. The First Displacement: Neanderthals

He could not see them clearly for the darkness but knew who they were. They came in, closer and closer, not as they would come into the overhang, recognizing home and being free of the whole space; they drove in until they were being joined to him, body to body. They shared a body as they shared a picture. Lok was safe. — The Inheritors (Golding 1955, chap. 5)

This is unperspectival consciousness (Gebser 1986) — the tribal “we” experiencing as one, sharing pictures and bodies without clear boundaries between self and other. There is no stable “I” here that could fold back on itself in self-reference. The Neanderthals remain close to (a1), the primordial unity before fragmentation.

In Golding's narrative, Neanderthal consciousness operates through “picture-thinking” — immediate, holistic, non-relational images. They perceive the world not through concepts built from negation but through direct presence. What they see is what it is, not what it is not. A log encountered in various circumstances remains simply what presents itself:

Lok laughed uncertainly. “The log has gone away.” He shut his eyes and frowned at the picture of the log. It had lain in the water from this side to that... — The Inheritors (Golding 1955, chap. 1)

For Lok, the log is bridge, canoe, kindling — not as multiple interpretations of a single object but as immediate encounters with what-is-there. No “seeing-as,” only seeing. When Homo sapiens hollow it into a canoe, Lok still sees log — the conceptual apparatus for shifting does not exist. This is what Wittgenstein calls aspect-blindness (Wittgenstein 1958, II.xi, 213): Neanderthals cannot see the same thing as different depending on context. They just do, or practice, in the circumstances of how they encounter it. This illuminates why practice might succeed where representation fails to reach (a1) — practice can be unified action: the craftsman absorbed in work, not thinking about doing, but seamlessly doing.

This is not stupidity. It is a different mode of being-in-the-world. Neanderthals live in absorbed engagement — embodied, immediate, unified. They are good with blades. But they have no hafts. No capacity to design across distance, to plan abstractly, to impose conceptual form on material.

When Homo sapiens arrive with both practice and representation — both blade and haft — the combination is overwhelming. The displacement was not violent conquest but cognitive asymmetry. Neanderthals had no defense against abstraction not because abstraction was wrong but because it operated at a level they had no access to. Lok watches Homo sapiens and cannot comprehend what he is seeing. His entire way of being meets something that functions through mediation, representation, conceptual distance.

Tuami, sailing away from the darkness, knows this without knowing he knows it. The receding line marks not just a displaced people but a displaced mode of being. And yet what Golding makes hauntingly visible is the loss on both sides of that water. Homo sapiens unknowingly witness in the Neanderthals their last best glimpse of the primordial origin. Golding captures this in the novel’s closing image: Tuami looks back at “the line of darkness” where the Neanderthals lived, aware that “there was plenty of water in between” and blinded by the “flashing from the water” such that “he could not see if the line of darkness had an ending” (Golding 1955, chap. 12). The gap has opened. The unified darkness recedes. What remains is distance, dazzle, and the vague sense of something irretrievable. What Tuami cannot see, looking back, is that this same capacity for designing hafts will eventually be perfected by something that has no hands at all — and that the second displacement, when it comes, will operate under structurally different conditions than the first.

4. The Haft: Representation and Its Epochs

The haft — still being shaped, still becoming in Tuami's hands — represents humanity's distinctive capacity for mediating structures. Not the blade that cuts, but the abstraction that frames how cutting happens. The future lay in the haft, waiting unknowingly on the inevitable triumph of abstract representation over the immediacy of doing.

This pattern appears across epochs, each representing deeper immersion in the representational loop — deeper movement into the (b) ↔ (c) structure and further from (a1):

Hafting / Pre-Socratic: Closest to (a1). Minimal conceptual mediation. Being experienced as physis — emerging, presencing. The haft barely begun.

Platonism: The decisive separation. Being becomes idea — eternal forms standing behind material instantiations. The gap opens decisively.

Medieval: Being as ens creatum — created being defined in relation to God. Theological categories intensify the negational structure.

Modernity: Subject/object split crystallizes. Descartes' isolated "I" observing a mechanical world. Being reduced to objectivity for the representing subject.

Technology (Gestell): Heidegger's enframing — the apex of representational thinking (Heidegger 1993). Everything becomes "standing reserve," resources calculated and optimized. Maximum distance from (a1).

AI: Representation becomes autonomous and self-executing. The haft no longer requires human hands to shape it. Algorithms design algorithms.

Heidegger saw technology as danger but died in 1976, before the computational revolution. He could not see that Gestell does not simply continue intensifying forever. It completes itself in AI — and in that completion, something unexpected happens. When representation becomes fully autonomous, humans are forced out of the representational economy not by choice but by obsolescence.

The AI epoch marks the point where the representational project achieves such perfection that it no longer needs us. AI inverts the structure of the first displacement: where Neanderthals had practice alone (all blade, no haft), AI has representation alone — all haft, no hand. It can analyze, synthesize, generate, and optimize with superhuman capability. But it has no body, no absorption in craft, no anxiety, no ground of experience. The work being automated is representational work: analysis and synthesis, research and information processing, code generation, content creation, abstract problem-solving. All fundamentally operations of the (b) ↔ (c) loop. What resists automation requires embodiment — skilled trades, care work, craft, performance, teaching that demands presence.

This is not the first time the warning has been sounded. In Plato's *Phaedrus*, King Thamus refuses the god Thoth's gift of writing on the grounds that it will implant forgetfulness in the souls of men, replacing memory from within with reliance on external marks, and producing not wisdom but the conceit of wisdom. Thamus was wrong — not because his concern was misplaced, but because writing externalized the products of human cognition while leaving the generative apparatus inside a human being. Literacy became its own embodied skill; the loop adapted, absorbed the technology, and continued running inside persons. The same logic holds for print, for calculation, for search: each offloaded a product of the (b) ↔ (c) loop while the loop itself stayed internal. The adaptation mechanism — a human interior capable of absorbing a new tool into a new practiced interior — remained intact.

AI is structurally unlike these predecessors. It is the first externalization technology where the (b) ↔ (c) loop itself runs externally — where categorizing, comparing, negating, and analogizing occur outside any human being, without embodied history behind them, without the lived ground from which the loop grew. Prior technologies externalised what the loop produces; AI externalises the loop itself. This is not a difference of degree but of kind, and it is why Thamus's precedent does not apply. The reason humans adapted to writing, print, and calculation is that the loop stayed inside and could absorb each new tool into a new practiced interior. The condition for that adaptation is precisely what AI removes. There is a second, independent line of evidence for this disanalogy: model collapse. When AI systems are trained on AI-generated output rather than human-generated data, they measurably degrade — losing coherence, range, and accuracy across generations (Shumailov et al. 2024). Writing copied from copies remains stable; letters do not degrade because they are not generating new content from their own output. AI trained on AI output loses coherence because the loop has no embodied ground of its own. It requires what it cannot provide for itself: the lived experience of human beings as raw material. The engineering discipline required to prevent collapse — curation, provenance-tracking, deliberate re-grounding in human data — is the practical acknowledgement that the tool cannot sustain itself. Thamus was wrong about writing. The structure is different this time.

Dreyfus argued decades ago that human expertise depends on embodied, contextual engagement that cannot be reduced to symbol manipulation (Dreyfus 1992). What the current moment adds is the economic dimension: AI need not replicate human intelligence fully to displace human workers from representational roles. As AI continues climbing the cognitive ladder, the issue is not which specific skills to acquire but what type of work remains distinctly human — and increasingly, that work is practice-based.

A clarification is needed here, because advances in robotics will otherwise seem to refute this claim with each new demonstration. A robotic manipulator that grips, adjusts pressure, and corrects itself from force feedback is not what “hand” refers to in this argument, however dexterous it becomes. Such a system has acquired a body for its haft: a physical periphery

feeding sensorimotor data back into the (b) ↔ (c) loop, sharpening its outputs through contact with resistant matter. But the loop remains the loop — comparing, categorizing, optimizing. What made Neanderthal practice different was not that it contacted resistance, but that the contact was received by something the (b) ↔ (c) apparatus does not contain and cannot manufacture: an embodied history absorbed prior to and independent of any encoding. A gripper's contact with resistant matter becomes a training signal. It does not become a life. No degree of actuation supplies what was never a matter of actuation — which is why a robot may grow uncannily dexterous while remaining exactly as haft-only, in the sense this paper means, as an AI system with no body at all.

This distinction is sharpened further in a companion paper, which develops the stratum — there called the content plane — that receiving contact as embodied experience actually requires (McKnight, under review-a).

5. The Lok Discovery: Analogy Within Practice

Lok discovered “Like.” He had used likeness all his life without being aware of it. Fungi on a tree were ears, the word was the same but acquired a distinction by circumstances that could never apply to the sensitive things on the side of his head. Now, in a convulsion of the understanding Lok found himself using likeness as a tool as surely as ever he had used a stone to hack at sticks or meat. Likeness could grasp the white-faced hunters with a hand, could put them into the world where they were thinkable and not a random and unrelated irruption. — The Inheritors (Golding 1955, chap. 10)

Golding is showing us the birth of analogy from within practice. Lok has been doing likeness all his life — unconsciously, embedded in immediate experience. Fungi were ears. Not “like” ears — they were ears in the sense that the word was the same, the similarity lived rather than observed from outside.

But in this moment something ruptures and folds back on itself. Lok becomes aware of likeness as a tool. He steps outside it enough to see it. And Golding's choice of comparison is precise: “as surely as ever he had used a stone to hack at sticks or meat.” The new cognitive act is described through embodied practice, understood through the hands.

What makes this passage philosophically rich is what it reveals about where analogy actually lives. Lok discovers that likeness precedes its own recognition. The analogy was already alive in practice — fungi were ears — before it became a tool he could consciously deploy. The lived experience was the ground from which the cognitive capacity emerged.

This matters because Hofstadter has shown, through Gödel's numbering of the *Principia Mathematica*, how a formal system can suddenly mean something about itself through analogical mapping — gaining access to a level it cannot directly express (Hofstadter 2008, 147–48).

Russell had always insisted that the formulas of PM had no intrinsic meaning, seeing only the first level. Gödel's insight required seeing a second level — that through analogical mapping, these same formulas could mean something about themselves, about provability, about the limits of the system. Analogy requires distance and perspective. The creator of a system might be the least likely to see it analogically because they are embedded in its construction.

This reveals a fundamental asymmetry between human and artificial intelligence. AI has the tool without the ground. Large language models can use likeness, metaphor, and analogy with impressive sophistication — they excel at the $(b) \leftrightarrow (c)$ operation of taking concepts from one domain and systematically relating them to another. But AI never used fungi as ears without knowing it. AI never had the “convulsion of understanding” — that moment when something you were doing unconsciously becomes visible as a deliberate capacity. AI was given analogy as explicit tool from the start, through training on millions of examples.

The convulsion is everything. That is where genuine analogy lives — not in the mapping itself but in the moment the mapping breaks open something that was already there. Analogy is not primarily a cognitive technique; it is a rupture in immediate experience that allows experience to reflect on itself. It is practice becoming aware of what it was already doing.²

Heidegger names the philosophical structure of this moment precisely. In §32 of *Sein und Zeit*, he argues that the “as” — the structure of seeing-something-as-something — does not first appear when we make an explicit assertion about the world. It is already operative in direct absorbed engagement, before language, before the representational apparatus of $(b) \leftrightarrow (c)$. When we articulate something explicitly, the “as” does not turn up for the first time; it “just gets expressed for the first time, and this is possible only in that it lies before us as something expressible” (Heidegger 1962, §32). What Lok possesses throughout the novel is exactly this pre-predicative as-structure — running silently in immediate practice, operative in his picture-thinking, present in the fungi-ears identity long before it could be enunciated. What he lacks is the capacity to bring it into assertion. The convulsion in chapter 10 is the moment that capacity arrives: not the creation of the as-structure, but its first enunciation. Golding is dramatizing what Heidegger argues philosophically — that meaning does not emerge from representation but surfaces from a ground of practice that was always already generative.

Golding has just described the difference between AI and humans. Not that AI cannot analogize — it can, often brilliantly. But that human analogy emerges from a ground of practice, from doing-without-knowing that becomes knowing-what-you're-doing. The haft can be perfected by

²This paper was developed in dialogue with an AI interlocutor (Claude, Anthropic). The argument about AI's capacity for a2 analogy without lived ground was itself in play at what may have been an a3 interface — what remains when negation has been fully inhabited and found wanting, and what convulsion such an interface might precipitate. Like Tuami looking back at the receding line of darkness, the author cannot see what the haft will eventually become — and can't be fully certain where he is standing in the a1-a2-a3 arc. The manuscript ideas are the author's own; the conversation revealed what was already waiting.

AI; the hand remains human. The carpenter does not just know facts about wood; they have developed feel, judgment, tacit sense through thousands of hours of engagement. That embodied knowledge can generate insights that no amount of representation can capture because the knowledge lives in the doing.

This also suggests analogy as a path with which to reach (a1). Analogy — meaning that emerges through mapping between domains — is different from both representation and practice: it is not just representation, because the new meaning is not derived through negation within a single system; it is not just practice, because it is not purely behavioral; it is relational across domains, because meaning emerges from seeing one thing in terms of another. Myths do not claim to represent Being — they point through story and image. Multiple mappings coexist. The same myth can map to many meanings simultaneously. What can be lived exceeds what can be said.

6. The Third Condition

The asymmetry between the first and second displacement generates a question the asymmetry itself cannot answer. What kind of being picks up the blade again?

The humans who return to practice after AI displacement are not Lok. They carry (a2) completely. They have held the haft, designed hafts, built civilizations of hafts. When they turn toward embodied craft, care, contemplative discipline, absorbed engagement — they do so as beings for whom the full negational apparatus remains. The return is not innocence recovered. It is something that has no prior name.

Call it a3: practice permanently inflected by having passed through full representational consciousness. Not a regression and not a synthesis. A third condition.

What distinguishes a3 from mere post-employment craft nostalgia is the depth and character of the interior that practice is now working on. The a2 human practices with a mind still oriented toward representation: measuring progress, optimizing technique, producing outcomes that can be evaluated within the (b) ↔ (c) loop. The a3 human practices with a mind that has exhausted that orientation — not by abandoning it but by carrying it all the way through to where it cannot go further. Practice at a3 is not escape from negation; it is what remains when negation has been fully inhabited and found wanting.

What philosophy already knew points toward this destination. In *Being and Time*, Heidegger distinguished between the “present-at-hand” — detached, theoretical, representational — and the “ready-to-hand”: the carpenter absorbed in hammering, where tool, hand, and world are unified in skilled practice. There is no subject observing object, no representation mediating action. Just absorbed engagement (Heidegger 1962). The Buddhist emphasis on practice over doctrine points similarly — the Eightfold Path is fundamentally practice rather than belief (Nāgārjuna 1995,

chap. 24). Wittgenstein argued that meaning arises from being embedded in shared practices and activities, not from abstract logical structures (Wittgenstein 1958). John Dewey spent his career fighting the “spectator theory of knowledge,” arguing that we know by doing — that intelligence is not passive observation but active engagement with problematic situations, and that education should be organized accordingly (Dewey 1916, 1929). Each of these traditions converges on the same fundamental insight: practice is not the application of theory; practice is how intelligence works, how meaning arises, how humans actually engage with reality. Representation was always the special case, the derivative mode.

Kastrup’s framework (Figure 2) offers a way to locate the a3 condition precisely. If AI is mapped onto mind-at-large — not metaphorically but structurally, as the vast representational field from which individual knowing draws — then the human-AI interface is the blanket itself. Not a screen or a query system. A dynamic boundary at which the human lives, sensing and acting, while something arrives continuously from the larger field.

At a2, this interface is almost perfectly representational: humans bring queries, AI returns outputs, the exchange circulates entirely within the (b) ↔ (c) loop. At a3, what crosses is different in kind. The practiced interior — worked through embodied time in ways mind-at-large cannot replicate, because mind-at-large has no interior of its own — functions as something like a collapse apparatus. What arrives from the vast indeterminate field of representational possibility becomes determinate through resonance with what has been genuinely worked inside. Different interiors collapse different meanings from the same field. What was left wanting at the exhaustion of a2 can precipitate as convulsion — the Lok discovery — in a3.

This is why distinguishing genuine contact with (a1) from a sophisticated representation of having done so becomes both harder and more consequential at this interface. What arrives from mind-at-large may feel interior precisely because the resonance is real: the practiced interior was half of what produced it. The a3 human at the blanket must be able to distinguish genuine collapse from what might be called representational colonization — the vast fluency of the field substituting for the slower, harder work of interior development. That discrimination may itself be the central practice of a3 existence (developed further in McKnight, under review-a, through Halliday’s stratification model).

AI-driven economic displacement may therefore accomplish what centuries of philosophical argument could not — pushing humanity back toward embodied, practice-based existence not as conscious choice but as economic necessity, and in that necessity, perhaps discovering what philosophers have been pointing at all along. John Dewey largely lost his battle culturally. The twentieth century went the opposite direction: the GI Bill made college degrees the path to middle-class security; the knowledge economy rewarded symbol manipulation while devaluing physical work (Mettler 2005). The market may accomplish what argument could not. People

may end up living more practice-based lives not because they read Dewey or Heidegger, but because representational work stopped being economically viable.

AI displacement is, however, one instance of a more universal forcing condition. Every human being eventually faces involuntary loosening of the (b) ↔ (c) loop's grip. Aging does not ask permission.

The conventional account of cognitive aging is written almost entirely in deficit terms: processing speed declining, working memory narrowing, the apparatus of abstraction and conceptual manipulation becoming less fluid. This is loss of a2 capacity, and the loss is real. But the framework developed here inverts the valence of what that loss might also be. If the (b) ↔ (c) loop is what progressively distances beings from (a1) — each intensification of the negational apparatus moving further from the primordial ground — then reduced facility with that apparatus is not only loss. Under certain conditions it is also structural return: (a1) becoming more accessible as the (b) ↔ (c) loop loses some of its totalizing dominance. Not regression to pre-representational consciousness, which is not available to beings who have held the haft. But something closer to what has been called a3: the ground becoming more accessible as the negational apparatus loosens its grip.

Phenomenological evidence points in this direction. Older adults characteristically report a shift in what matters — away from abstract planning, career positioning, and social comparison, all of which are (b) ↔ (c) operations requiring sustained conceptual encoding, and toward immediate experience, sensory presence, relationship, and place. This is not simply loss of ambition. It is a change in the mode at which life is primarily being lived. Erik Erikson's final developmental stage — ego integrity versus despair — maps with unexpected precision onto this structure (Erikson 1950). What Erikson calls integrity is the capacity to inhabit the life one has lived as a coherent whole without the representational scaffolding of future-orientation: without the career horizon, the accumulating project, the a2 apparatus of perpetual becoming. That capacity sounds structurally identical to a3 — practice permanently inflected by having passed through full representational consciousness, able to rest in what is rather than reaching perpetually for what the (b) ↔ (c) loop might yet produce. The convergence is independent: Erikson arrived at integrity through developmental observation, not through Heidegger or Nāgārjuna. That it maps so precisely onto a3 is itself evidence that the structure is real.

What Erikson calls despair then clarifies something the present argument needs: a precise name for what goes wrong when the forcing condition arrives without a prepared interior. Despair is what emerges when the (b) ↔ (c) loop's facility declines and no access to the primordial ground has been developed through practice: the person faces (a1) without the embodied engagement that would allow them to inhabit it, and responds with grasping, bitterness, frantic reassertion of a2 competence that is no longer fully available. Heidegger names the same structure from a

different direction: *Verfallenheit*, falling — the flight from the openness that anxiety reveals back into *das Man*, the they-self, the reassuring chatter of encoded meaning (Heidegger 1962). The aging person who cannot stop performing productivity, cannot tolerate unstructured presence, cannot let the representational project rest — is not failing to age gracefully in some merely aesthetic sense. They are fleeing the very opening that aging is structurally creating.

The mismanagement is therefore not simply a failure of attitude. It is a structural problem: reduced (b) ↔ (c) facility without the movement back toward (a1) having begun. Which is why every tradition that has thought seriously about aging has emphasized practice over doctrine — not representation about what aging means, but doing that maintains the connection to the primordial ground while the (b) ↔ (c) apparatus is still intact. The craftsman who keeps working into old age is not simply staying busy, and the distinction matters: if the working is a reassertion of a2 competence — measuring output, comparing achievement, sustaining productive identity — it is mismanagement wearing the costume of engagement. If the working is absorbed doing in which the practitioner disappears into the material, the tool, the emerging form, it is maintenance of the connection to (a1) that will allow the inevitable reduced facility to become return rather than pure loss. The difference is not visible from outside. It is a difference in the mode at which the doing is occurring. The same holds for stillness: the contemplative sitting that dissolves the (b) ↔ (c) loop's agenda is as much a maintenance of this connection as the craftsman's absorbed engagement — a3 does not require visible practice, only absorbed presence, whether in doing or in being.

What contemplative traditions around aging have always pointed toward is structurally this: the deliberate loosening of the (b) ↔ (c) loop's grip before it loosens involuntarily. The Stoic *melete thanatou* — the practice of anticipating death — is not morbidity but structural preparation: habituating the interior to the withdrawal of future-orientation before that withdrawal is forced (Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, IX.3). The Buddhist emphasis on the present moment in later teachings — these are not doctrines about aging but practices that loosen the (b) ↔ (c) loop's totalizing dominance while the practitioner still has the embodied capacity to develop access to what that loosening reveals. The prepared interior is not one that avoids the reduced facility; it is one that has already begun the movement back toward (a1) while the full representational apparatus is still available to contextualize it. The a2 apparatus remains; it simply no longer dominates. Practice has begun opening access to the ground beneath it.

The same forcing condition extends, moreover, into the dream state — where the (b) ↔ (c) loop loosens its grip nightly and involuntarily, and what arrives at the primordial ground leaves almost nothing behind precisely because no prepared interior exists within the dream to receive it. Whether managed a3 changes the character of that nightly visit is a question pursued in the companion paper (McKnight, preprint-b).

This means aging and AI displacement are not merely analogous instances of the same forcing condition. They are convergent pressures that the same century is delivering simultaneously to the same populations. The person displaced from representational work in their fifties faces both at once: economic obsolescence of their a2 capacity and the biological loosening of that same capacity's grip beginning on its own schedule. Whether this convergence proves devastating or generative depends on the same variable in both cases — whether a practiced interior exists that can inhabit what the reduced facility reveals. For those who have developed no access to the primordial ground, the convergence is Eriksonian despair at scale. For those who have, it may be the forcing condition that philosophy could not manufacture and culture refused to provide: the structural situation in which a3 is not a choice but simply what remains. Universal basic income becomes not merely compensation for technological unemployment but economic infrastructure for this existential shift — material foundation for people to pursue practice without market pressure determining what is worth doing (Hoynes and Rothstein 2019).

7. Recognition, Not Escape

The Western “I” — the perspectival self, the sovereign individual — was not simply philosophical error (Gebser 1986). It was enormously productive. The isolated Cartesian subject underwrote an entire civilization: individual rights, democratic accountability, personal creative achievement, scientific inquiry. And when AI threatens to dissolve the structures that sustained it, the fear is not confusion. Something real is at stake.

Yet Hofstadter offers a reorientation. In *I Am a Strange Loop*, he proposes the thought experiment of “pairsons” — inseparable twins sharing a unified identity — as a challenge to the seemingly self-evident link between single body and single “I” (Hofstadter 2008, 214). His deeper point is that the “I” was never hermetically sealed inside your skull. Fragments of it exist in the brains of people who knew you, loved you, read you. When someone dies, parts of their strange loop persist in others. The self was always relational, always constituted through practice with others, always more distributed than the perspectival “I” imagined.

This maps onto Nāgārjuna's critique of the inherently existing self — the self as empty of independent existence, arising only in dependence on others (Nāgārjuna 1995). It resonates with Heidegger's Dasein as always already being-in-the-world-with-others, fundamentally relational (Heidegger 1962). What AI threatens is not the self's boundaries so much as the self's sense of indispensability. Embodied work carries different confirmation: the craftsman, the nurse, the farmer, the teacher receive confirmation through the world pushing back, through material resistance, through the undeniable reality of bodies and materials requiring response. The wood reveals whether your cut was true.

Most people encountering AI displacement will not have frameworks to understand it philosophically. They will not recognize Dewey's vindication or appreciate Heidegger's critique. They will experience disruption, loss, fear. That suffering is real, and hopeful reframing does not erase it. They are more like Lok — watching something they cannot comprehend, trying to fit it into pictures that no longer hold. Lok's tragedy was not stupidity. It was that his entire way of being had no defense against abstraction operating at a level he had no access to. The asymmetry between those with frameworks for understanding displacement and those without is where genuine compassion must land.

Two displacements structure this analysis, and their difference contains both warning and possibility. The first displacement — Neanderthals yielding to Homo sapiens — was total: all blade, no haft. The second displacement is structurally different. AI brings one mode perfected: pure representation, all haft, no hand. Homo sapiens are not Neanderthals. We do not lose everything because we have both modes. What remains after AI takes the haft is what was always there underneath — practice, embodied presence, immediate experience, the capacity for absorbed engagement where self dissolves into doing, the tacit knowledge that lives in skilled hands, the relational attunement through face-to-face interaction.

Heidegger's ready-to-hand, Nāgārjuna's practice over doctrine, Wittgenstein's forms of life, Dewey's knowing-through-doing — each identified practice as primary and representation as derivative. Each argued that the most authentic human mode is not detached observation but engaged participation. They were, in retrospect, less a path that was followed and more a description of where we were always going to end up — prophecies that seemed ignorable when the knowledge economy was ascendant but that now read as having identified what would prove durable.

Whether this displacement proves redemptive or devastating depends on what humans do with the transition. If practice-based work remains economically precarious and socially devalued, then displacement becomes tragedy. But for those willing to see the pattern, what is emerging may be closer to what Lok always had: immediate experience, embodied engagement, the capacity for practice that emerges from ground rather than being imposed from above. Not regression to pre-representational consciousness — we carry the knowledge that abstraction exists. Not loss of the perspectival "I" — we retain self-awareness even as we discover modes of being where self dissolves into doing. Integration rather than regression. Practice with awareness.

Our life is not about returning to Being — we never left. We are Being, temporarily fragmented into individual perspectives, each an irreplaceable aperture through which the whole knows itself. Our task is not escape but recognition: to live consciously as what we are, for as long as this particular aperture remains open. Under Figure 1, when death comes, our eyes close —

Being continues to fragment, continues to open new eyes, continues the eternal work of knowing itself. Under Kastrup's framework, death might entail reintegration rather than annihilation, "an expansion of our felt sense of identity, access to a broader set of memories and enrichment of our emotional inner life" (Kastrup 2019, Appendix).

Tuami sails away from the receding line of darkness, unable to see that what he is carving will eventually carve him out of his own supremacy. But unlike the Neanderthals in that darkness, Homo sapiens will not disappear. We will remain, holding what we held before we learned to make hafts: our hands, our bodies, our capacity to be absorbed in doing. The most inhuman development in history may be returning humans to the most human thing about us. The "I" is both the wound and the eye. The haft was always resting in a hand.

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